

Amritsar

THE HOLY SEAT OF SIKHISM

This magical city, which was founded by Guru Ram Das, the fourth Sikh Guru, is home to the holiest site of the Sikh religion—**Harmandir Sahib**, better known as the **Golden Temple**. Amritsar gets its name from Amrit Sarovar, the holy tank the Golden Temple is built around. The building opposite the Golden Temple is the Akal Takht, the highest seat of earthly authority of the Khalsa. Twice a day, the Guru Granth Sahib moves between the Golden Temple and the Akal Takht in a Palki Sahib procession which is a sight to behold. The Guru ka Langar at the Golden Temple, which 75,000 to 100,000 pilgrims partake every day, is among the largest community kitchens in the world and should not be missed.

Amritsar is an atmospheric city filled with old bazaars, gurdwaras, temples and heritage sites and eateries serving delicious local specialties like Amritsari kulche, kaali dal and Amritsari fish. The makeover of the road stretch from Town Hall to Sri Harmandir Sahib, called **Heritage Street**, has dramatically transformed the street which every visitor to Amritsar will invariably take. While Hall Bazaar is a famous historic marketplace, there are also many malls in Amritsar now.

Jallianwala Bagh is a historic garden and 'memorial of national importance' very near to the Golden Temple, preserved in the memory of those wounded and killed in the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre of 13 April, 1919. Housed in the Town Hall building, **Partition Museum** is the first museum to record the trauma that resulted from the Partition of India in 1947. Tourists can use the **Hop-On-Hop-Off** bus service to visit the major sights. Other major attractions include **Gobindgarh Fort, Sri Durgiana Temple, Maharaja Ranjit Singh Museum,** and **Bhagwan Valmiki Tirath Sthal (Ram Tirath)** and the newly built **Jallianwala Bagh Centenary Memorial** during the 100th year commemoration of the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre. An interesting experience is **Sadda Pind**, a 'Punjabi culture

living village museum' spread across 12 acres where you can get an authentic taste of Punjab.

The biggest attraction outside Amritsar is undoubtedly the **Attari-Wagah border**. Every evening, the military showmanship at the border between India and Pakistan gets infused with patriotic fervour as a huge crowd gathers to watch the ceremony of closing of the border gates and lowering of flags of both the countries. On the way to Attari lies the **Punjab State War Heroes' Memorial & Museum**. There is no way you can miss the gigantic 45-metre sword jutting out into the sky. **Sarai Amanat Khan**, a monument built in 1640 by Amanat Khan, the calligrapher for the Taj Mahal, lies 17 kms from the Attari Border and 30 kms from the Golden Temple.

The city of Tarn Taran Sahib, 30-min from Amritsar, is home to **Gurdwara Sri Tarn Taran Sahib**, a prominent Sikh shrine.

Sprawling over 4,000 hectares, **Harike Wetlands**, also called **Hari-ke-Pattan**, lies 56 kms from Amritsar. The wetlands are northern India's largest manmade wetlands and a birdwatcher's paradise.

Truly, there is much to do in and around the city of Amritsar.